# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

**Kaja Kallas**, the vice-president of the European Commission, rejected America's assertion, made in a national-defence document last year, that Europe is facing "civilizational erasure". Ms Kallas was speaking at the Munich Security Conference, where a day earlier Marco Rubio, America's secretary of state, won over the audience by playing up ties between the allies.

**Gavin Newsom**, the Democratic governor of California, took a different approach to reassuring America's European allies, telling them that "Trump is temporary." Earlier the president of the European Commission, Ursula von der Leyen, said that "some lines have been crossed that cannot be uncrossed". Britain's prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, admitted that America's security umbrella had allowed Europe to develop bad habits, but added "we must break them".

Yvette Cooper, Britain's foreign secretary, threatened sanctions against Russia after five European countries said it was "highly likely" that a poison developed from the Ecuador dart frog killed **Alexei Navalny**, a Russian opposition leader. They blamed the Kremlin for his death, two years ago, in a Siberian penal colony.

The Russian government denied the accusation, describing it as the "feeble-mindedness of Western fabulists".

America's armed forces said they had carried out a series of strikes against **Islamic State** targets in **Syria** over the past two weeks. The strikes were in retaliation for an ambush in December that killed two American soldiers and an American civilian interpreter. US Central Command said at least 50 members of IS have been killed or captured since the ambush.

Gunmen reportedly killed at least 30 people in raids on several communities in northern **Nigeria**, where such armed groups are known as bandits. Nigeria has long faced several interlocking security crises; both bandits and jihadists menace the country's north-west, and they are increasingly threatening the central regions. Earlier this month jihadists killed around 170 people in the mid-western Kwara state.

Casey Wasserman, an American talent agent, said he was selling his firm after his ties to **Jeffrey Epstein**, a dead sex offender, emerged in emails released by the Justice Department. Chappell Roan, a singer, and other clients have left the agency in recent days. He insisted he "never had a personal or business relationship" with Epstein. He will keep his role as organiser of the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

Organisers indefinitely postponed **Cuba's** annual **cigar festival**, which was scheduled for the end of February, blaming America's fuel blockade. In January the Trump administration placed an effective embargo on foreign-oil shipments to the island, which has suffered power cuts and shortened the working week. In 2025 the festival's cigar auction yielded more than $18m, which apparently supports Cuba's health-care system.

**Word of the week:** Alpha, the name of a Christian starter course that has become one of Britain's most successful cultural exports.

Read the full story.

Photograph: Reuters

## The rift between Washington and Jerusalem

Binyamin Netanyahu's emergency visit to the White House disappointed him. On Wednesday Israel's prime minister urged Donald Trump not to seek a nuclear agreement with Iran. In a post after their meeting America's president wrote, "I insisted that negotiations with Iran continue to see whether or not a Deal can be consummated." In a rare show of discord between the two leaders, Mr Netanyahu said before returning to Israel that he had not hidden his "general scepticism about the possibility of reaching any agreement with Iran".

Israel fears that a deal would focus on Iran's nuclear programme, which was significantly damaged by Israeli and American bombing in June, rather than on its ballistic-missile arsenal, which Iran has used to attack Israel. Mr Trump, who said he was sending a second aircraft-carrier to the region, is for now keeping his options open.

Photograph: AP

## The limits of MAGA solidarity

On Sunday, after attending the Munich Security Conference, Marco Rubio is going to Slovakia and then to Hungary. But it's not clear whether he will meet Viktor Orban, the Hungarian prime minister, who is both Russia-friendly and an admirer of the Trump administration's anti-immigration policies.

Mr Orban would no doubt welcome a photo-op with the American secretary of state. He is fighting to be re-elected in a parliamentary vote scheduled for April 12th. Donald Trump has endorsed him. However, neither MAGA backing nor Mr Rubio's visit to Budapest is likely to influence the election much. Hungarian voters care mainly about the sorry state of the economy and health-care system and about corruption. Neither Mr Trump nor J.D. Vance, his vice-president, is expected to visit Budapest before the election.

Photograph: Getty Images

## Weaponising cricket in south Asia

It is impossible for India and Pakistan to play a game of cricket against one another without politics getting in the way. But even by their antsy standards, the build up to Sunday's clash in the Twenty20 World Cup has been torturous.

This time the row has centred around Bangladesh. The governments of India and Bangladesh fell out when Bangladesh's despotic prime minister, Sheikh Hasina, was ousted in 2024. In January India's cricket board forced one of its domestic teams to sack a Bangladeshi player. When Bangladesh then demanded its World Cup games be moved from India to Sri Lanka, the sport's India-dominated governing body kicked them out of the tournament.

Enter Pakistan, which said it would forfeit its game against India in solidarity. Given that India-Pakistan games are one of the most-watched sporting contests on the planet—and thus extremely lucrative—that was a severe threat. On Monday, however, Pakistan had a change of heart, and agreed to play. After all the posturing, some sport is about to break out.

Photograph: National Gallery of Art, Washington D.C

# The seascapes of Georges Seurat

Georges Seurat is known for grand, luminous paintings of Parisian life, such as “A Sunday Afternoon on the Island of La Grande Jatte”. The French artist pioneered the pointillist technique, using small dots and dashes of colour to create his pictures. Yet more than half of the paintings Seurat finished in his short life were of the sea.

The Courtauld Gallery in London has put Seurat’s seascapes on show together for the first time, assembling around 23 paintings and a few drawings. Every summer from 1885 to 1890 Seurat escaped his studio in Paris for the sea. Visiting Grandchamp, Honfleur, Port-en-Bessin, Le Crotoy and Gravelines, he captured the cliffs, beaches and ports of France’s northern coast. On his trips he sought to capture “the bright light, in all its nuances”. The effect, as captured in this sublime exhibition, is a collection of canvases that brim with pearly grey and blue.

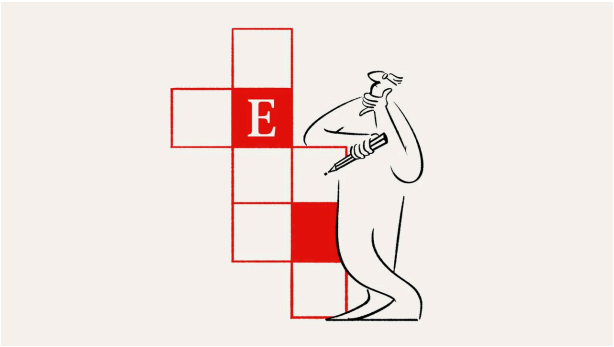


Illustration: The Economist

# Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

## Cryptic clues

*1 across* - Military garb sounds like it will get your motor running (5)

*2 across* - Propose a flat surface (5)

*3 across* - An Aussie pickup with some road ahead knows where to go (5)

*1 down* - I'm a streaker, weirdly, for Britain's first among equals (4,7)

## Straight clues

*1 across* - The army's favourite shade (5)

*2 across* - An elementary display of facts or figures (5)

*3 across* - The right direction (5)

*1 down* - SW1A's most powerful knight, for now (4,7)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to [email protected]. We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

# The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

**Guillaume Laroch**, Calgary, Canada

**Maria Manuela DaCosta**, Eau Claire,aq Wisconsin, America

**Sverre Prytz**, Zurich, Switzerland

They gave the right answers of The Ugly Duckling, Alcatraz, Wales, Prince Harry and Madison Square Garden. The theme is Clint Eastwood films: "The Good, the Bad and the Ugly", "Escape from Alcatraz", "The Outlaw Josey Wales", "Dirty Harry" and "The Bridges of Madison County".

The questions were:

**Monday:** In which Hans Christian Andersen tale does the main character turn out to be a swan?

**Tuesday:** Which American prison was home to both Al Capone and Machine Gun Kelly?

**Wednesday:** Cymru is the alternative name for which nation, part of Britain?

**Thursday:** Who is currently fifth in line to the British throne?

**Friday:** Which Manhattan venue is home to the New York Knicks?

*Power concedes nothing without a demand. It never did, and it never will.*

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***Frederick Douglass***